

The installation process

This next part of the guide steps you through installing Ubuntu alongside Windows.

Step 2: Select Install Ubuntu

Once you've started up Ubuntu from the USB stick or CD, the first thing you will see is an option to Try Ubuntu or Install Ubuntu. Select your language from the left hand side and click on Install Ubuntu.

Step 3: Keyboard and Language

Next select your keyboard layout and language. Press Continue.

Step 4: Updates and Other software

You'll be asked to choose which installation type you want. The default is 'Normal installation'. Leave that as-is.

You'll see Other options also. Two tickboxes; one for 'Download Updates whilst installing Ubuntu' and the other 'Install third-party software for graphics and Wi-Fi hardware and additional media formats'. Make sure both of these are ticked, as per the image below.

Press Continue.

Step 5: Partitioning your disk

This step is the most tricky. Hint, it's not really tricky at all!

For this example, I have Windows 10 on this PC. For whatever reason, I'd like to keep that and install Ubuntu alongside it.

This is the easiest option to choose if you want to keep Windows because the Ubuntu installer takes all the pain out of partitioning your hard drive.

Alternatively, you can choose to 'Erase disk and install Ubuntu'. If you select this option then Windows will be no more. If you've got a system that you're done with and you want to start with a blank slate, then this option is for you. This option is the easiest of them all.

Finally there is another option called 'Something else'. We won't go into this one for this guide, however this allows you to manually create partitions in the way you want them to be.

I've selected 'Install Ubuntu alongside Windows 10'. I have clicked Continue.

The next screen allows you to resize your Windows Partition (ntfs) to the size you want, freeing up enough space for Ubuntu.

Have a look at the below screenshots. You can see that by default the Ubuntu installer has decided to give most of the space (30.6GB to Windows). It set 22.5GB to give to Ubuntu. I decided that this was a bit miserly, so I slid the size of the Ubuntu partition to the left, so it was equal in size to the Windows partition. Below you can see the before and after screenshots.

- Use the arrow slider mouse cursor to resize your windows partition
- I've resized them to be 50/50 in size

Once you are happy with the sizes, Press 'Install Now'.

Next, you'll be asked to confirm that you want to make the changes to the disk. Press Continue to both.

- Accept the resize action
- Accept the changes to the disk

Step 6: Location

The next few items are all fairly self explanatory. Choose with location you are in the world so that your time zone and regional settings are appropriate to you. Once you have selected the right one for you, press 'Continue'.

Step 7: Usernames and the Administrative (root) user

The final step is to set up a user account and set the name of the computer.

Tux tip!

In the below screenshot you can see that I've put my name as 'The Ultimate Linux Newbie Guide'. Of course you would enter something like 'Jane Doe' in this field.

The computer's name can be whatever you want it to be. When it is seen by other devices on your home network, this the name it will be seen as.

The next item is to select a username to use to log in with, etc. Don't use your full long name here, use something without spaces. For example 'jdoe'.

Note that Ubuntu always sets the first user specified as an administrative user. This means that as you are the first account on the machine, you will get to do privileged tasks. Such tasks for example; install software, update the system and deal directly with hardware. Take this information with a little caution. If you are asked again for your password when doing something in Ubuntu, it is asking you to escalate your own privileges into what Linux calls the 'root' user. Root is simply the username of the administrator in Linux. As administrator you have free reign over the system at all times. Do not perform tasks as root unless you know what you are about to do, or unless you have confidence in the task ahead!

A little word on passwords

At this point you'll be asked to set a password for your username. It's important that you select a strong password, because in time to come, you may wish to open up services such as remote access onto your machine. It's a simple step but believe it or not, still a reasonably effective method of security, do not choose a simple word as a password. Choose random things, like for example, your favourite colour, and your first car, with a few numbers (maybe your year of birth) sprinkled in the middle for good measure. Here is a pretty strong password and could be pretty memorable to the right person:

`blue77volvo!240GLS@`

No, I wasn't born in 1977, my favourite colour isn't blue, but my dad did have a Volvo 240GLS! However, you get the idea. The password is still important, especially if you ever run any server or sharing software on your machine in the future. Having a secure password makes sense.

Once you are satisfied that you have set a name, username, password and computer name that you are happy with, Press 'Continue'.